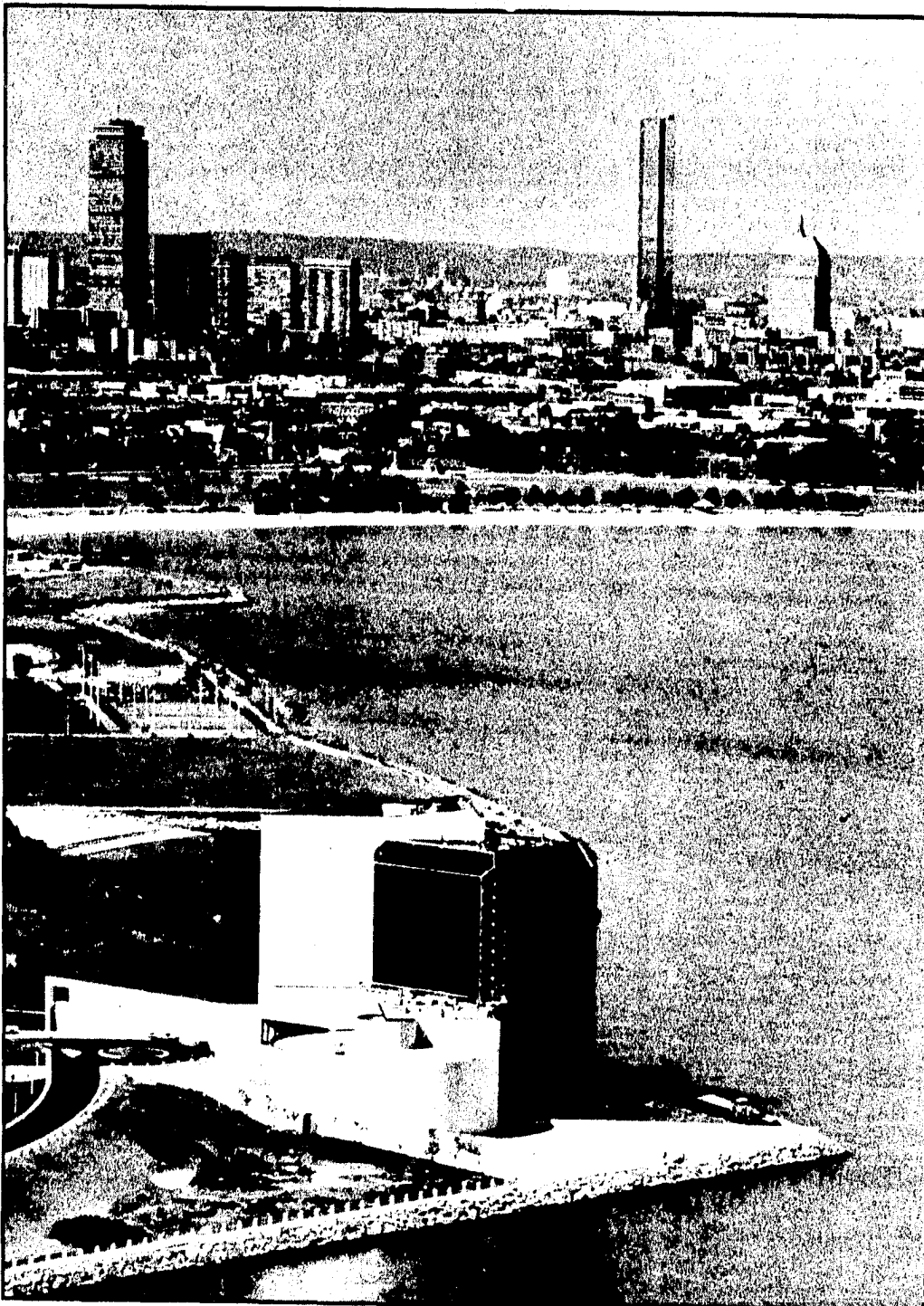




Architect I.M. Pei's Kennedy Library: the 'White Tower by the Sea.' (Globe photo by William Ryerson)

The new resident of Columbia Point

By Robert Campbell

On Columbia Point — the old Boston dump site — the famous and powerful will gather next Saturday to dedicate what is probably the most controversial and surely the longest-awaited American building of our time.

Ieoh Ming Pei's Kennedy Library stands there at last, in chalk white concrete and pale gray glass, facing out to sea and looking as if it had been meeting the weather on this peninsula for as long as the white cliffs of Dover, which it somewhat resembles.

For the first time in the library's long and checkered history, it has the air of being the right building in the right place. Fifteen years after Pei started designing for another site in Cambridge, it even seems like the right time, or at least a dramatic time, as another presidential contest with a Kennedy involvement begins.

When I. M. Pei got his commission in 1964, it must have seemed a dream job. Pei was just emerging into national prominence. Jacqueline Kennedy said she chose him because, as with JFK, his best work was still to come. Fifteen years later, Pei has been through the John Hancock Tower and the East Building of the National Gallery in Washington, has won the Gold Medal of the American Institute of Architects and achieved international fame.

All that time, people argued over and waited for this building. The result justifies the agony.

Outside, the Kennedy Library is grand and commanding rather than beautiful, like a rugged natural feature of the landscape rather than merely a handsome building. Inside, the brilliantly organized spatial sequence leaves you filled with admiration.

If we as a society really need to erect these triumphal arches to our Presidents — and, obviously, judging by the way we

throng to visit them, we do — then I. M. Pei has shown how to do it.

The whole library is organized, inside and out, around one great ceremonial space. This is the hundred-foot-high gray-glass atrium that looks out over the harbor, the islands and the open sea. This atrium must contain something like one-third the volume of the whole building, but it has no contents except an enormous American flag, a bench, and, on one wall, a lettered quotation from President Kennedy. The atrium's mission is symbolic, not functional. "It is filled," says Ted Musho, Pei's associate on the job, "with your thoughts."

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Climbing up one side of this atrium are six stories of office floors, each with a curving glass outlook over the great space. Here the staff and visiting scholars will work, their lives, too, focused on the atrium.

"If the building inspires, then architecture has played its role," Pei says of this building. The same might have been said by the designer of a Gothic cathedral. And indeed the underlying pattern of the Kennedy Library resembles a church or cathedral.

The atrium, soaring, empty, flooded with light, is like a cathedral nave. The

two round theaters at its side, where visitors will see a film about Kennedy, are like curving chapels. Just as the stained glass of chapels tells of the life of saints and heroes, so the bright film images tell the tale of JFK.

Beneath the theaters, where in a cathedral the crypt with the relics would be, is the main exhibition area, displaying more than 300 objects from JFK's life, plus photographs, TV films, and other mementoes of his family's and his administration's history.

The visitor moves through all this in a wonderfully calculated way. After a first, teasing glimpse of the atrium and the sea from the entry lobby, you pass into one of the theaters for the 35-minute film. You exit one level lower than you entered and find yourself in the windowless exhibition area. You emerge from that — or more accurately, you explode — onto the floor of the dazzling atrium. You then rise along broad stairs within the atrium to pause, in good weather, on a tree-filled outdoor terrace before passing through the bookstore and the lobby — with another glimpse back at the atrium — and so outside again.

It's a sensationally theatrical organization of movement through space, far subtler and better than Pei's overpraised East Building in Washington.

Outdoors, the building juts toward the harbor like a big ocean liner, with JFK's boyhood sailboat beside it on a riprap seawall. Quiet landscaping and marvelous sea views make the outdoors a success. Indeed, the strongest long-term impact of the library may be the way it focuses Boston Harbor and makes the islands seem part of the city. Instead of feeling like the end of the world, Columbia Point now seems the beginning of the islands.

What will surely puzzle people most about the building is its exterior appearance. Pei's goal was to make his building a monument, a symbol, the way the Lin-

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Robert Campbell is *The Globe's* architecture critic.

JFK Library worth the wait

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coln and Jefferson memorials are symbols on the water in Washington. The problem architecturally is how you make a monument if you deny yourself all those Roman columns that the architects of the Lincoln and Jefferson memorials were so free with.

Buildings like those achieve symbolic power through their romantic associations and recollections. We are trained all our lives, starting with the pictures of the Parthenon in schoolbooks, to respond to them. The truth is that we rarely like buildings that don't "look like" something familiar. That is why the movement in architecture called "Post-Modernism" is once again introducing nostalgic recollections of older styles into architecture.

But not Pei. He remains a mainline Modernist, refusing to make a building that will trade on our preconceived notions of beauty.

The result is that few people are going to love the Kennedy Library because of anything it "looks like." It looks like a grain elevator, a lighthouse, a chalk cliff, maybe like the iceberg colliding with the Titanic. Though its contents are packed with nostalgia, its appearance lacks any.

Pei realized, too, that no familiar, measurable building of this size could possibly hold its own in so vast a setting. So he omits all indications of size from his building — floor lines and even windows are invisible from the approach view — and instead creates a big, scaleless sculpture, piles it up as high as possible, and so triumphs over the vast site.

The success of the building settles some old questions and raises some new ones. First of all, once you've seen it you can't imagine it, or anything like it, in Harvard Square, although this building is actually smaller than what was first proposed there. The library is far more at home here, with room for parking, for dignified approach, for expansion. And here, surely, on publicly owned land, there will not be the rash of commercial rip-offs that were dreaded in Harvard Square and are a reality elsewhere, such as the Greyhound Hall of Fame (for the great buses) and the Hall of Generals Wax Mu-

seum that disfigure the Eisenhower Library in Abilene, Kan.

But other questions remain. It was Ada Louise Huxtable in the *New York Times* who eloquently asked, "When did our presidents get into the competitive Pantheon business?" John Kennedy himself, according to his friend, the architect John Carl Warnecke, did not desire a monument like this. Warnecke accompanied Kennedy on his trip to choose a site near Harvard and later wrote:

"He was concerned with the large amount of glass and the unrelated, attention-calling geometric forms of the roof of Leverett Towers. He asked if it was not possible to have structures of contemporary design that were also harmonious with the environment."

It is possible, but you don't get a monument that way. A monument, by definition, sticks out. The building Kennedy spoke of would have fitted into Harvard Square. A Presidential Museum, a kind of Presidentland, designed and planned to be a major tourist attraction, as all presidential libraries now are, wouldn't fit in there and didn't.

But a monument was what was wanted, no matter what the press releases say. This fine building isn't here so that historians can have a pleasant place to untie the brown string around cardboard boxes of presidential documents, though that will happen too. It's here to celebrate a moment in American history, to punctuate the skyline of a city, to focus our sense of ourselves as a people — in short, to be a monument.

Though built from private donations, presidential libraries are owned and managed by the federal government, and there perhaps deserves to be national debate about the appropriateness of the program. A history of American culture could be written around these buildings. Kennedy's is much more modest than the Ozymandian LBJ pile in Austin, but it's a far cry, still, from the small frame house in Plymouth Notch, Vt., where Coolidge lived and was sworn into office by his father. The Coolidge home, because of its genuine connection with the President's life, remains one of the most meaningful of memorials.

But the question of whether a President's friends ought to erect a museum to him is a separate one from the question of how well this particular example has been designed. It's been superbly designed. After many traumas, it somehow emerged better than ever.

It was in 1961 that President Kennedy first announced he would donate his papers to the National Archives, to be housed in a building associated with Harvard University. In October 1963, he picked a site, across the Charles River from the main Harvard campus.

After Kennedy's death, a seemingly better, bigger site, the old MBTA car barns at Boylston street on the river, was offered by the Commonwealth and accepted. Meanwhile, the question of picking an architect was dealt with. Eighteen internationally known architects were invited to Cambridge to see the site and advise the family. After a day of debate, they all put names in envelopes and handed them to the Library Corporation. Pei's name was among those that appeared often in the envelopes.

Mrs. Kennedy visited buildings by various of the suggested architects and was struck by Pei's National Center for Atmospheric Research, in Colorado, which has the kind of empty, overwhelming site that Columbia Point was later to offer Pei. When she picked Pei for the job, it was 1964 and the library was expected to open within three years.

But it was 13 years before the MBTA could relocate its barns. Pei's first designs were presented at Cambridge community meetings in 1973. It was at once apparent from the designs that far more than a quiet home for scholars and documents was now planned. An 85-foot high Pharaonic glass pyramid, ancestor of the great atrium now on Columbia Point, led to questions about the number of visitors and the appropriateness of such a tourist attraction in crowded, small-scaled Harvard Square.

Though the building later shrank, tensions grew and, finally, in 1975, in the face of likely lawsuits, the Library Corporation announced it would move. It received

175 offers of sites and looked hard at the Navy Yard in Charlestown before accepting the University of Massachusetts' offer of these nine acres at the tip of Columbia Point.

I. M. Pei went back to the drawing board and quickly produced the best of his many designs for this project.

Says Pei today: "After Cambridge, it was all downhill. It became easy. We knew the problem, we knew where we were going. In Cambridge we had a complex urban environment. Here, we have a

dialogue with Boston across the bay. It called for a symbolic solution to the problem. We did the whole design in six months."

The Library is inexpensive for its quality — about \$85 per square foot, excluding sitework, is the announced figure, little more than half the price of Washington's East Building. But the workmanship, as always with Pei, is meticulous. The precast concrete panels, lightly sandblasted, are white without glare and their joints are crisp. The eight-story gray glass

wall of the atrium is held up by a standard, off-the-shelf space frame of steel struts, unpretentious and elegant.

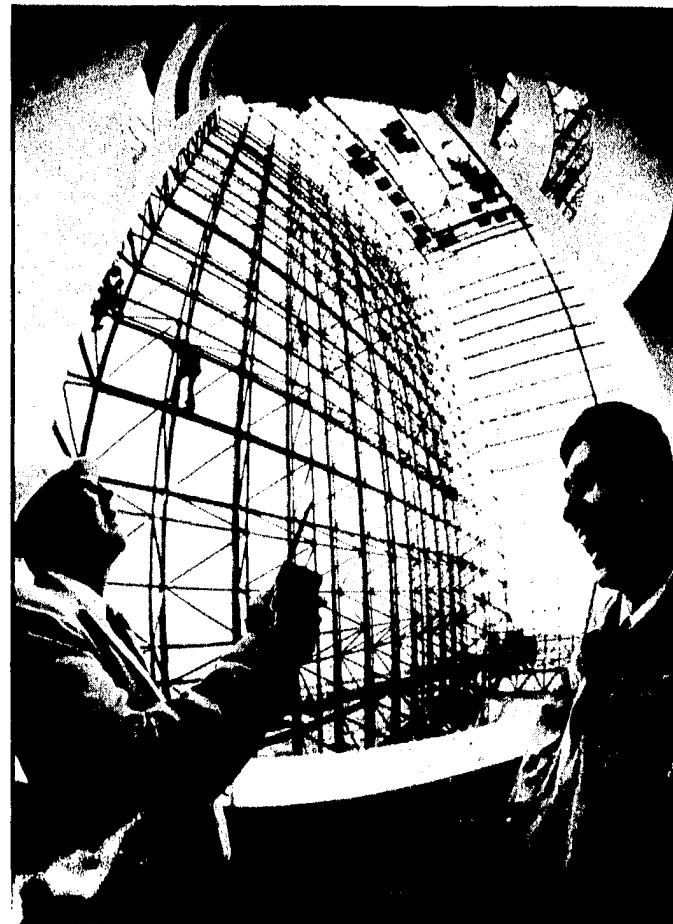
Like all buildings, the Kennedy Library is the work of committees as much as of any one designer. The Library Corporation, the Kennedy family, the staff headed by Dan H. Fenn Jr., various friends such as Arthur Schlesinger Jr., and the General Services Administration were all among the cooks who stirred the broth. One senses that the architect had his irritations with so hydra-headed a client, but if so it doesn't show in the product.

The exhibition floor was turned over to a consultant, the New York graphic design firm of Chermayeff and Geismar. They have selected and arranged their material in a chronological timeline, winding around a central focus that contains a replica of JFK's desk (the original is in the Oval Office). Backlit photos, objects, and text follow the history of the President, his family and their times, beginning with the Irish immigration of 1840. There are audio recollections by Rose Kennedy, and TV monitors replay news events of the day. In this dark space, with spotlighted pictures, words and objects, one feels surrounded by media rather than by reality, but the effect is handsome, informative and understated.

The film, by Charles Guggenheim, wasn't available at this writing.

Upstairs are the tiers of floors for the archives, the scholars who will use them, and the staff. Here is the amazing historical collection. There are 115,000 still photos, 6 million feet of motion pictures, 1000 tapes and discs, oral histories taken from 1000 people who recall Kennedy, and 150 collections of personal papers including, rather oddly, those of Ernest Hemingway. There are the papers of John and Robert Kennedy, some 25 million pages of them. And there are more than 15,000 objects, of which the 315 on display are but a tiny sample. Using these materials, the Library will host seminars and other educational activities in Boston and around the nation.

It's an ambitious program, and it's housed in an ambitious building. Boston should welcome and be proud of what Dann Fenn, an Irishman who knows a symbol when he sees one, calls "the White Tower by the Sea."



Jack Greenip, project executive for Turner Construction, and Ted Musho of I. M. Pei Associates, the project architect, in the atrium area of the new Kennedy Library. (Globe photo by Ted Dully)